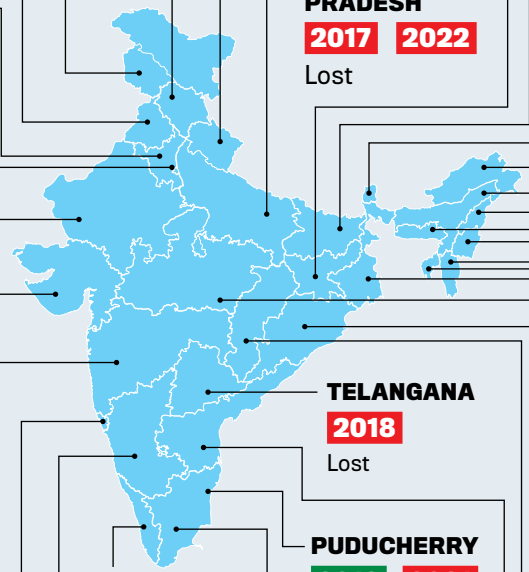
2014, the BJP has usurped the Dalit and OBC votes. In 2019, the saffron party netted 41 per cent of the Dalit and 51 per cent of the OBC vote while the Congress got 28 and 18 per cent, respectively, according to the INDIA TODAY-My Axis survey. Several surveys have shown how the Congress's share of the Muslim vote dwindled from more than 40 per cent before 2014 to around 30 per cent in 2019.

The Congress is aware that it desperately needs a message to counter the politics of polarisation. Six high-powered subject committees have been formed to deliberate on the economy, politics, farmers' issues, social justice, organisation and youth. Most leaders talk about propagating the founding principles of the Congress—social justice and inclusion, celebrating diversity and secularism. But they are still groping in the dark to articulate it in an electorally effective language. CWC member and general secretary in-charge of Rajasthan Ajay Maken is hopeful that the Congress will be able to lure the young, aspiring voter with the "exemplary governance" records of Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh.

What about having a mascot like the BJP has in Narendra Modi to deliver the message? Rahul, clearly, has failed to be one. Three-time Lok Sabha MP Shashi Tharoor, however, believes this may indirectly benefit Congress in the long run. "I see the BJP projecting a one-man show, the PM as the

PAST IMPERFECT

Since 2014, the Congress has lost two consecutive Lok Sabha elections and has been on the losing side in 36 of the 50 assembly elections in the past eight years



PUNJAB 2017 2022 — Won in 2017, lost in 2022

J&K 2014 — Lost

HIMACHAL PRADESH 2017 — Lost

UTTARAKHAND 2017 2022 — Lost

UTTAR PRADESH 2017 2022 — Lost

HARYANA 2014 2019 — Lost

DELHI 2015 2020 — Lost

RAJASTHAN 2018 — Won

GUJARAT 2017 — Lost

MAHARASHTRA 2014 2019 — Lost in 2014, joined the ruling alliance in 2019

GOA 2017 2022 — Was single-largest in 2017 but could not form government, lost in 2022

KERALA 2016 2021 — Lost

KARNATAKA 2018 — Second-largest party, formed government with JD(U), fell in 2019

TELANGANA 2018 — Lost

PUDUCHERRY 2016 2021 — Won in 2016, lost in 2021

TAMIL NADU 2016 2021 — Lost in 2016, part of the ruling alliance in 2021

JHARKHAND 2014 2019 — Lost in 2014, part of the winning alliance in 2019

BIHAR 2015 2020 — In 2015, was part of winning grand alliance, lost in 2020

SIKKIM 2014 2019 — Lost

MADHYA PRADESH 2018 — Won and formed government which fell in 2020

ODISHA 2014 2019 — Lost

CHHATTISGARH 2018 — Won

ANDHRA PRADESH 2014 2019 — Lost

ARUNACHAL PRADESH 2014 2019 — Won in 2014 but 44 Congress MLAs later defected to BJP; lost in 2019

ASSAM 2016 2021 — Lost

NAGALAND 2018 — Lost

MEGHALAYA 2018 — Was single-largest party but could not form government

MANIPUR 2017 2022 — Was single-largest party in 2017 but could not form government, lost in 2022

MIZORAM 2018 — Lost

TRIPURA 2018 — Lost

WEST BENGAL 2016 2021 — Lost

Win & Loss in the assembly election year